
Church Website

Project Plan & Page Architecture

A first-visit-focused website for a Nigerian Pentecostal church (Port Harcourt / Rivers State).

Primary goal: compel a first-time **physical** visit. Online livestream is a fallback, never a co-equal call to action.

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Stack: Next.js (App Router) · TypeScript · Tailwind CSS
Date: 29 June 2026 · Status: draft for review

How to read this document

Anything in [BRACKETS] is a real-world detail not yet confirmed — service times, address, names, photos. These must be filled from the actual church; they are not assumed here.

Three features are marked **CONDITIONAL** (Give, Testimonies, Sermon archive). They are pending the church's decision and are architected to slot in without rework — not built unless cleared.

1. The one idea this whole site is built on

Almost every page on this site funnels to the **same single destination: the “Plan Your Visit” page**, and the site’s real conversion is a first **physical** visit. A church website’s job is not to advertise or to sell — it is to **reduce the anxiety of walking in cold** so that a friend’s invitation becomes easy to accept.

Because of this, the site deliberately does **not** push a different action on every page. Consistency is the strategy: four of six pages point to Plan Your Visit, and the livestream is kept visually subordinate so it never quietly tells an anxious first-timer “you don’t actually need to come.”

Design rule

If a page is being designed to funnel somewhere *other* than Plan Your Visit (or a low-friction WhatsApp question), stop and ask whether that page is earning its place. The strength of this site is that it points everything at one door.

2. Sitemap & navigation

Six core pages. Navigation stays at ~5 visible items so it never overwhelms on a phone. “I’m New” earns a top-nav slot because it is the primary conversion path; Contact does not, because the floating WhatsApp button already does the “reach a human” job on every page.

Top navigation

Home · I’m New · About · Events · Watch

Repeated buttons

“Plan Your Visit” + “WhatsApp” — present on every page

Footer

Contact (address, map, phone) · Give [conditional] · service times

#	Page	Role
1	Homepage	The trailer — proves “real, warm, here’s when/where” in ~5 seconds
2	Plan Your Visit / I’m New	Keystone — kills first-visit anxiety; most-designed page
3	About	Who we are + how the church functions (substantial, but shaped)
4	Events	Proof the church is alive; a low-commitment on-ramp
5	Watch	Livestream + latest service — a fallback, framed as such
6	Contact	Footer-linked. Canonical address/map for trust + local SEO

Why Contact is NOT in the nav (but still exists)

In a WhatsApp-first design, the floating WhatsApp button handles “reach a human” on every page, so the Contact page’s old job is already done site-wide. What remains is a canonical home for the address + map + phone + service times — valuable for trust and for Google’s local search (a consistent Name/Address/Phone). That is a **footer** job, not a nav job. Every nav slot competes with “I’m New,” the actual money path; spending one on a utility page the WhatsApp button already covers is a bad trade.

3. Page-by-page architecture & funnels

3.1 Homepage

Job: Be the trailer, not the movie. Most visitors skim — design for the skimmer. Arrivals come from a member's shared WhatsApp link, "church near me" search, or the Google Business Profile.

Section order (top to bottom):

- **Hero / above the fold** — real congregation photo; one-line identity ("A Pentecostal family in [neighbourhood], Port Harcourt"); **service times + location visible without scrolling**; primary button **Plan Your Visit**; secondary **Message us on WhatsApp**. A strong still image — no autoplay video.
- **"New here? Here's what Sunday looks like"** — 3–4 reassuring beats (how long, what to wear, kids, the welcome) → link to Plan Your Visit.
- **A glimpse of us** — small, optimised photo strip of real services/events. Faces, not the building.
- **Pastor's welcome** — one genuine photo, 2–3 plain, warm sentences.
- **Testimony [conditional]** — one short testimony if cleared (reusable section component).
- **Next event** — the single nearest upcoming event → Events page.
- **Can't make it in person?** — the subordinate livestream mention → Watch page.
- **Footer** — full address, map, Get Directions, phone, WhatsApp, service times, Contact, Give [conditional].

Funnel: Every section ends pointing at **Plan Your Visit**. WhatsApp is the persistent fallback (floating button + hero). No section is a dead end.

3.2 Plan Your Visit / I'm New — the keystone

Job: Kill the anxiety of walking in cold. This is the most-designed, most-important page on the site. Its purpose is to let someone *pre-live* their first Sunday so arriving feels like a return, not a first. It receives the highest-intent visitors.

Section order:

- **Warm opener** — "Thinking about visiting? Here's everything you need — no surprises."
- **The logistics, plainly** — service times; exact address with embedded map + Get Directions; where to park and which entrance; how long the service runs.
- **What to expect** — the honest emotional preview: the worship style (lively Pentecostal praise, prayer); what happens when you arrive; "will I be singled out?" (no); what to wear (come as you are vs. the real norm).
- **Your kids** — what happens for children, safety, where they go. A make-or-break question for parents that most church sites ignore.
- **A 30–60s welcome video or photo montage** (facade-embedded if YouTube) — seeing the room removes most of the fear.
- **Optional soft line** — "Got a question before you visit? Message us on WhatsApp." A no-commitment question link, *not* a sign-up form.

CHANGED — removed the pre-visit “ask” and the follow-up reassurance

Removed: the “tell us you’re coming” WhatsApp/form commitment, and the “we won’t show up at your house” reassurance that went with it.

Why: an uncertain person won’t declare an attendance they’re not sure of, so that form mostly captures people who would have come anyway — low signal. Data capture moves to the people who **actually arrive** (see §4).

Consequence to accept consciously: Plan Your Visit becomes a purely informational, anxiety-reduction page with no single online conversion event. That is coherent — the conversion now happens in the building — but it means “is the website working?” is inferred from attendance and word-of-mouth, not from form submissions. The low-friction *question* channel still exists via the global WhatsApp button, so the page is not a dead end.

Funnel: No commitment ask. The page’s output is a visitor who **feels ready to show up in person**. The optional WhatsApp link serves pre-visit questions only.

3.3 About

Job: Answer “who are you, and can I trust you?” — **and** “how does this church actually function?” This page carries real substance: the deeper, identity-and-conviction version of how the church operates (structure, beliefs, membership, departments, traditions, vision). The enemy is not depth — it is *undifferentiated* depth. Give it shape, not a wall of text.

Two versions of “how the church functions”, split by who is asking:

- **The newcomer’s version** (logistical, time-sensitive: how long, worship style, kids, what to do on arrival) lives on **Plan Your Visit** — they need it before Sunday.
- **The deeper version** (governance, departments/units, membership process, beliefs, traditions, vision) lives **here on About** — for the interested person who already wants to understand who you are.

Suggested sections:

- Who we are — a short, human introduction.
- What we believe — concise, plain language; not a theology dump.
- How the church functions — structure, departments/units, membership process, rhythms/traditions.
- Leadership — real photos and short intros.
- Our heart / vision — a few lines.
- Closing CTA — Plan Your Visit.

Funnel: About removes objections rather than converting directly; it ends by handing the reassured reader to **Plan Your Visit**.

3.4 Events

Job: Prove the church is alive, and offer a low-commitment on-ramp — an event can feel easier to attend than “church.”

- Upcoming events first (nearest at top): date, time, location, one-line “what it is”.
- Past events optional and below — mostly photo evidence of community life.
- Kept current: a stale past event at the top is a credibility killer. Pruning is part of the weekly rhythm.

Funnel: Each event → a WhatsApp “I’d like to come to [event]”, or for a newcomer, back to **Plan Your Visit**.

3.5 Watch — how it works

The livestream is live ~2 hours on Sunday and dead the other 166 hours, so the page has **two states**, both designed deliberately. Confirmed: the church streams every Sunday on YouTube and Facebook.

Live state (Sunday, during service):

- A clear “We’re live now” banner with the embedded YouTube player, plus a link to the Facebook stream.
- This is the one time it’s fine to load the real player immediately — the person here is actively choosing to watch.

Not-live state (the other 166 hours):

- Shows the **most recent service** as a thumbnail using the facade / lite-embed pattern — just an image until tapped, then the real player loads.
- Shows the next live time so they know when to come back.
- Keeps the physical visit primary even here: top line “In Port Harcourt this Sunday? We’d love to see you in person — plan your visit,” then below, “Can’t make it? Watch live or catch the latest service.”

Build decisions:

- **Feature YouTube as the on-site player; link out to Facebook.** YouTube facades cleanly; Facebook embeds are heavy and flaky.
- **Update the “latest service” link manually each week** as part of the 15-minute content rhythm. Only wire up the YouTube Data API later if the manual step becomes a genuine chore.
- Distinction: “Watch Live” (confirmed, ships now) is **not** the same as a browsable “Sermon archive” (conditional — a separate, later add-on).

Funnel: Primary nudge at the top to **Plan Your Visit**; the watching itself is the fallback action.

3.6 Contact (footer-linked, not in nav)

Job: Canonical Name/Address/Phone + map, for trust and local SEO. Lean by design.

- Address, embedded map, Get Directions, phone, WhatsApp, service times.
- No elaborate email form that nobody will monitor.

Funnel: Light. Its real value is being correct and consistent for Google, not converting. WhatsApp + Plan Your Visit buttons still present.

4. Data capture & follow-up — a real-world step, not a website page

Replacing the removed online “ask”: details are collected from the people who **actually came**. After the service, a first-timer is welcomed and given a short connection form. This produces warm, real data and focuses follow-up effort on genuine leads rather than hypothetical ones.

The in-person connection form captures:

- Name
- Phone number (the WhatsApp follow-up channel)
- Any prayer request — a culturally natural, non-transactional reason to give details in a Nigerian Pentecostal setting, and a warm bridge to follow-up.

Follow-up

Follow up via WhatsApp within 24–48 hours — warm and personal, not a sales pitch. Speed of follow-up strongly predicts whether a first-timer returns. This step lives in the church’s welcome process, not on the website, but the website exists to get them through the door in the first place.

5. Conditional features (pending church decision)

Architected to slot in without rework — built only if cleared. Status to be confirmed with the church.

Feature	How it slots in	Status
Give / Donate	Standalone /give route + one footer link; Paystack or Flutterwave; understated, level, clear, equal hero CTA. “Give now”	CONDITIONAL
Testimonies	A reusable section component (not a page). Renders into Home and Plan Y. Confirmed; renders n	CONDITIONAL
Sermon archive	A browsable library of past sermons — distinct from the confirmed Watch page. Dignified, facade-embedd	CONDITIONAL

6. Technical & performance notes

The audience is mobile-first, often on cheap Android phones over patchy, expensive data. Speed is a conversion *and* SEO issue, not a nice-to-have.

- **Images** (the heaviest part of a photo-led church site): WebP, compressed, correctly sized, lazy-loaded below the fold. Use Next.js Image.
- **YouTube**: always facade / lite-embed (e.g. lite-youtube-embed / react-lite-youtube-embed) — load the real player only on tap. A naive iframe can pull a megabyte+ of JS before playback. (The embed *technique* is what matters, not which page it sits on.)
- **Hero**: a strong still, not autoplay video; minimal/deferred JavaScript.
- **Delivery**: caching + CDN; fast host. Test on a real low-end Android over throttled 3G — emulators understate real load times. Target sub-3-second loads.
- **Local SEO**: fully populated Google Business Profile (photos, hours, category “Pentecostal Church”), consistent Name/Address/Phone, Church schema markup, local keywords (“church in [neighbourhood], Port Harcourt”), and Google reviews.

7. Low-maintenance content rhythm

The site is event-and-photo-driven, not a sermon archive — which fits a volunteer-run church. The blog is intentionally cut for launch; add it later only if a real writer commits (a two-post blog from months ago signals “nobody’s home”).

- One volunteer, ~15 minutes weekly: update the next event, add a few fresh optimised photos, refresh the “latest service” link on Watch.
- Monthly check: service times and contact details still correct; no stale past events sitting at the top of the Events page.
- Occasionally rotate one or two testimonies [if cleared].

Open items before the next build step: confirm Give / Testimonies / Sermon-archive status with the church; fill every [BRACKET] with real church details (times, address, neighbourhood, names, photos). Next step once those land: break the Homepage and Plan Your Visit pages down to the component level (sections as React components, props, static vs. dynamic).